ACF · Historical content outside the current syllabus — Question Patterns and Methods

Based on 7 past-exam parts, 6 papers (2020–2025 mapped to the 2026–2027 syllabus), their marking keys and the examiners' reports.

First: where marks are lost most

- Answers state facts about the topic without relating them to the stimulus material. The Section Three reports say this lowered standards across both extended-answer questions, so tie every explanation to a named company, a result or a figure from the stimulus.
- Answers lack depth and specificity. Where a key award names a "reported result", a general statement earns nothing, so cite the actual reported item each time.
- Students leave later parts unattempted. In Question 21 the number attempting all parts fell from part (a) to part (e), which the reports suggest may reflect poor time management; in Question 22 the number stayed consistent across those parts. Budget time per part and keep moving.
- Students stop when they cannot answer one part. The reports say that not answering one part does not stop the other parts from earning marks, so attempt each remaining part.
- Two-sided parts lose half the marks when one side is missing. The 4-mark costs-and-income part awards 2 marks for two costs and 2 marks for two income sources, so give both sides with two distinct points each.

Pattern 1: Explain historical corporate social-disclosure requirements

How often: 3/6 papers · 6.0 marks when it appears · 1.3% of a paper.

Recognise it: a stimulus about a company's social or environmental reporting, followed by a standalone question on who uses that disclosure and why, or on the difficulties of preparing it. Typical verbs are "explain the use made of", "describe three difficulties" and "explain the nature of ... through two examples".

Method

1. Read the stimulus and find the company's reported social or environmental information (for example a reported result or figure).
2. For a use or user question, name who uses the information (the company itself, then other users) and say what each does with it.
3. Tie each use to the specific reported result in the stimulus, not to CSR in general.
4. For a difficulties question, write three different difficulties, one per line, each from a different area (resources, measurement standards, reporting standards, format and location, timing, or incomplete or unbalanced disclosure).
5. For a two-example question, give two distinct corporate social disclosures that a company could make in a prospectus, and explain each one at full depth before moving to the next.
6. Keep each point to one clear sentence of explanation plus the link to the stimulus.

What the key rewards: in the key's order. For the use question, two awards: explaining how the company uses its own CSR data, and explaining how users use the CSR information, each referenced to a reported result. For the difficulties question (6 marks), the key lists six awards, one for each of six distinct difficulties: resources for measuring and reporting; the lack of consistent measurement standards; the lack of reporting standards that causes different presentation; differing locations and formats that make comparison hard; reporting timetables that do not match financial reporting dates; and incomplete or unbalanced disclosure that leaves out unfavourable information. The question asks for three different difficulties. For the example question, a 3-mark explanation for each of two relevant examples.

Common errors: stating what CSR is without naming a use or a user; describing the same difficulty twice in different words; giving a general list of disclosures rather than explaining two examples in depth; answering

with facts about the topic rather than with the stimulus material.

Past questions: 2023 EA Q22(d), 2022 SA Q20(d), 2021 EA Q22(e)

Pattern 2: Evaluate historical responsible-practice costs and income

How often: 2/6 papers · 4.0 marks when it appears · 0.6% of a paper.

Recognise it: a request to discuss, or to outline two each of, the costs and the potential income from socially or environmentally responsible practices.

Method

1. Identify the practice in the question (socially responsible or environmentally responsible).
2. Write the costs first. Give two distinct costs if the question asks for two.
3. Write the potential income next. Give two distinct sources of income, one clearly separate from the costs.
4. For a discuss question, weigh the costs against the potential income for the company, referring to the stimulus where possible.
5. Check that both sides of the question are covered before moving on.

What the key rewards: for the outline version, 2 marks for outlining two costs of socially and environmentally responsible practices and 2 marks for outlining two potential sources of income from them. For the discuss version, a single award for discussing the costs and potential income of environmentally responsible practices within a 4-mark part; the evidence pack does not give the mark value of that award.

Common errors: giving only one side (costs or income); giving two points that are really the same point; discussing costs without any income, or the reverse.

Past questions: 2024 EA Q23(b), 2021 EA Q23(b)

Pattern 3: Explain historical annual-report and standalone KPI purposes

How often: 1/6 papers · 8.0 marks when it appears · 0.6% of a paper.

Recognise it: a question asking for the purpose of annual reporting, together with how managers can use key performance indicators (KPIs) for accountability and for decision-making.

Method

1. Start by describing why annual reports are prepared and whom they inform.
2. Explain how managers use KPIs for accountability: comparing actual results against the targets set.
3. Explain how managers use KPIs for decision-making: making or revising decisions when results diverge from targets.
4. Keep the two KPI explanations separate, so each can earn its own mark.
5. Refer to the company in the stimulus where it helps (for example the company's KPIs).

What the key rewards: the key's three awards, in order: describing why annual reports are prepared or whom they inform; explaining how managers use KPIs to assess accountability against targets; and explaining how managers use KPIs to make or revise decisions. The part is worth 8 marks; the evidence pack does not give a mark value for each award.

Common errors: describing the purpose of annual reports in general terms without naming who they inform; treating accountability and decision-making as one point; listing KPIs without explaining how managers use them.

Past questions: 2023 EA Q22(a)

Pattern 4: Explain historical reporting institutions

How often: 1/6 papers · 4.0 marks when it appears · 0.3% of a paper.

Recognise it: a request to discuss the importance of a named reporting body or lobby group that is no longer on the current reporting-body list.

Method

1. Name the body and state its role in the financial-reporting framework.
2. Explain its oversight of the reporting framework and its standards-setting processes.
3. Explain why that oversight matters to users of financial statements, in one or two sentences.
4. Keep to the body's role rather than general accounting theory.

What the key rewards: a 4-mark discussion of the importance of the body, covering its oversight of Australia's financial-reporting framework and its standards-setting processes.

Common errors: describing the body without saying why it matters; general statements about accounting standards without linking them to the body named.

Past questions: 2024 EA Q22(e)

Pattern 5: Recognise superseded named financing products

How often: 0/6 papers (none in the evidence pack) · n/a marks when it appears · n/a of a paper.

Recognise it: a question that names a financing note or trust product that is specifically superseded, asked in the context of historical practice.

Method

1. Check that the question asks for historical practice, as the definition requires.
2. Identify the named superseded financing note or trust product in the question.

What the key rewards: no marking-key awards are recorded in the evidence pack, so the award order cannot be stated from the evidence.

Common errors: none recorded in the evidence pack.

Past questions: none in the evidence pack

Pattern 6: Recognise historical recommended-dividend treatment

How often: 0/6 papers (none in the evidence pack) · n/a marks when it appears · n/a of a paper.

Recognise it: a question that asks about a recommendation-only dividend requirement, asked as explicit practice of superseded content.

Method

1. Identify the recommendation-only dividend requirement that the question names.
2. Answer on the historical treatment the question asks for.
3. Answer on that basis only when the question explicitly practises superseded content.

What the key rewards: no marking-key awards are recorded in the evidence pack, so the award order cannot be stated from the evidence.

Common errors: none recorded in the evidence pack.

Past questions: none in the evidence pack